

ETHAN (TAEHOON) LEE

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Dear Hiring Manager,

Since choosing software engineering as my career, I have been searching for my niche in the industry. I began at the top of the stack. I designed UIs and published a research paper on human-computer interaction. Building web interfaces intrigued me to build the backend and data layer, where I designed APIs and implemented auth and caching. My internship at a cloud infrastructure team in Summer 2025 was an enlightening experience where I solved problems at scale with cloud-native technologies. Fallen in love with Kubernetes and its open-source community, I architected my own Kubernetes cluster to deploy personal projects and contributed upstream to Kubernetes, Next.js, and Echo framework. I went further down to work closely to the metal and operating system, as I entered CMU's master's program with a focus on distributed systems.

I've journeyed through the modern technology stack from top to bottom; I can build the frontend, backend, and the infrastructure to run them on. Counterproductively to my niche-searching, there wasn't a part that I didn't enjoy learning or building. Each layer of the stack came with different problems but taught the same lesson: there's always more than what I know. In today's world, maybe what I need is the passion and vision, not a niche.

I'm drawn to Protocol Nine because you're asking for RAG systems that get evaluated, not just built, and that's the part I've actually done. At Huddle Surety I built a multi-stage RAG pipeline with cross-document retrieval that generates bond documents, where a plausible-sounding wrong answer is a legal problem rather than a bad demo — so most of the work was ingestion, retrieval quality, and knowing when the pipeline should decline to answer. Security analysis has the same property. I'm also interested in the agent-harness side of what you do: I built a Helix plugin that turns inline code comments into a store an agent reads and writes through a CLI, which is my own small attempt at keeping a human in the review loop. I'd want to spend the internship on retrieval evaluation, where "did this work" is measurable.

I distinguish myself as a disciplined and curious learner with a breadth of engineering experience. Being a Software Engineer Intern at Protocol Nine is an opportunity that I am ready to make the most out of, and I hope my qualities include what you are looking for.

Sincerely,

Ethan (Taehoon) Lee